Nevertheless, as alluded to above, the nature of the material remains of past nomadic/transhumant societies is only one of a series of challenges surrounding their retrievability. Given that most of the textual sources emerged from urban and even courtly ambits (mentioned previously), it is unsurprising that non-sedentist populations appeared in these texts only in passing, the reports occasioned by their interactions with the hegemonic power in a particular region (cf. Chapter 1). Moreover, many texts' *raison d'être* was to chronicle a regional or transregional power and enable its longevity in collective memories, so that the official reports of this power's interactions with nomadic and transhumant groups rarely depicted them as anything but "barbarians" (cf. Chapter 1). The result, then, is a virtual *lacuna* of source materials on historical nomads that are contemporaneous and, if not sympathetic, then at least interested in the vast spectrum of nomadic existences.[40]

This historiographical blind spot can be somewhat ameliorated by studies of modern nomadic societies. While these studies by no means provide direct substitutes for the ideal source materials just described, they can offer documentation of phenomena in very specific contexts, providing interpretive *simulacra* that aid us in devising plausible interpretations of the surviving traces of past nomadic and transhumant groups. Bearing in mind Richard Tapper's[41] salutary cautions against the *a*historical use of studies on modern nomads to understand their historical antecedents, two broad parameters for their consultation are in order: first, relying on works treating modern Afghanistan and Iran for *comparanda* permits geographical consistency, underscored by an active awareness of the alterations in climate and natural resources within these regions' various landscapes over the last one thousand years.[42] Second, rather than a narrow, one-to-one application of modern data to past events, judicious *juxtaposition* tends to be less anachronistic, and more open-ended in the range of meanings that come into view. Within these parameters, the picture that emerges of the Shansabanis frames a shift from pre-imperial nomadism/transhumance among their fellow Ghuri countrymen, to a regional and then transregional dominance, albeit with continuation of some aspects of their earlier lifeways (see esp. Chapters 2 and 3).

This project's focus on an obscure, transhumant/nomadic group of the past, and the elites emerging from it, might appear to be an unlikely subject for an art-architectural historian. These populations certainly produced portable objects such as metalwork and textiles, made possible by their regular purchase or barter of raw materials in towns and settlements, where in turn they might sell or trade the fruits of their labors.[43] But they had no need to construct monumental architecture, generally not possessing the requisite skills themselves, nor patronizing specialized workers to build for them (cf. Chapter 2).

A premise of the current work is that Perso-Islamic kingship during the